

Deck of cards

Apacer has launched its new AE700 701 Embedded Card Reader.



USB Hub

Apacer has launched the funky looking PH152 USB 2.0 hub

a whopping Rs. 36,000. It has a brilliant menu system but the lower bezel is annoyingly wide, unlike the other NEC displays.

The ASUS VK266H also looks neat, with a smooth black finish and a slim bezel, despite the two-megapixel web camera built into the top bezel. This monitor has good build quality. The menu layout is very good but the control buttons are horrible.

AOC's 2434Pw rounds off the large monitors. It's also the cheapest, at Rs. 14,500, but isn't any shabbier looking for it. AOC uses a rather unique colour scheme – silver and piano white and quite honestly it's a refreshing change from the usual black LCDs we come across. In fact, this display is well built and has a very neat tilt mechanism. The only sore point is that the barrel of the stand pokes above the top bezel, and if the display is viewed at eye level the tip of the barrel is visible – not exactly an eyesore but an aesthetic flaw to be sure. Its resolution is exactly 1920 x 1080, meaning it's designed to be used mainly for watching movies.

Performance

The ASUS VK266H did well in the reverse text tests with only white on yellow and cyan on green being hard to read. The 16-shade ramp test didn't do well with the colour red, where three blocks, the 9th, 10th, 11th block on the top row looked similar. The contrast ratio tests were also mediocre, and there was a noticeable orange tinge to things when viewed from wide horizontal angles. Vertical viewing angles are impossible due to the TN panel under the hood although we noticed this panel was worse than some of the other TN panels around and a slight change in the vertical viewing angle changes the picture characteristics significantly. The rendition of green was good, while we noticed banding when displaying reds and blues. With its good brightness and contrast this monitor is good for games, but movies will be a problem, if only due to the poor viewing angles.

AOC's 2434Pw surprised us with its performance – it did far better than we expected and belied its price. Owing to its TN panel, the colour rendition in Display Mate was really poor and the 256-shade ramp test revealed a highly deficient colour gamut. None of this was too evident in the movie test and other than a few glitches everything looked fine. It also has pretty decent viewing angles for a low-end display. NEC's AccuSync 24WMCX didn't have as wide a colour gamut as the other two NEC displays and although it did well in the Display Mate tests we weren't impressed with it because of the price tag. It's good for



AOC 2236Vw

movies and games, although the contrast ratio isn't as good as we'd like for bringing out the finer detail in F.E.A.R.; but Crysis looked pretty good.

On to the other two NEC displays, both of which are based on high-end LCD panels. For some reason the MultiSync 2690WUXi seemed not to have as fast a pixel response as the MultiSync 2490WUXi2, but this is not very noticeable. We found the contrast to be slightly inadequate for some scenes in the video clips where we felt some detail was missing from the darker areas of the screen. But to be honest, it's only MVA and PVA panels that can improve on the performance of these displays, as most IPS panels do not have as good contrast ratios. Both these monitors provided an amazingly

rich experience with Crysis and the highlighted detailing on the bodysuit and weapons was something we've not seen before. The vividness of colour, contrast and the level of detail provided are pretty amazing and it's hard not to smile after gaming or watching movies on these monitors. The MultiSync 2690WUXi also has the widest viewing angles and betters its excellent sibling in this regard.

Conclusion

With sterling colour performance that was accurate and very close to an ideal colour gamut, the NEC MultiSync 2690WUXi was the undisputed winner of our Best Performer award. It's equally suitable for image professionals and multimedia/gaming junkies. It's also remarkably well built. Its sibling, the MultiSync 2490WUXi2, comes very close to it but loses out because of its slightly worse viewing angles. The only pinch is the price, i.e. Rs. 90,000. A shade below is the 2490WUXi2 priced at Rs. 83,000. If you demand the best, shell out big – you'll

cry but once. These NEC panels are also a must for any sort of work that demands high colour accuracy. If you need studio grade colour accuracy in your work and desire a flat panel you have no option but to shell out for an IPS or PVA panel or one of their derivatives. If you're looking for a large panel on the cheap, and colour accuracy isn't that important to you, check out the AOC 2434Pw – at Rs. 14,500 you will not find a comparable display at a better price.

22-inch monitors – Settle for no less

We received 13 monitors in this category, obviously the most populous one in this test. Although the native resolution for a 22-inch monitor is usually 1680 x 1050 pixels, some

of these displays supported 1080p with a resolution of 1920 x 1080 pixels; these are obviously aimed at movie buffs wanting HD content without the ugly black bars on the top and bottom of the picture. Widescreen displays can either support an aspect ratio of 16:10 or 16:9; the former is a better all-purpose resolution while the latter is better for purely HD content. Most 22-inch displays are based on cheaper TN panels and this is why they are so affordable. We were shocked to see a couple of displays priced at well below Rs. 9,000; something we didn't think possible. The market is flooded with 22-inch monitors, and there is no dearth of choice, so if you are still holding on to a smaller monitor, whether CRT or LCD, now is the time to spend.

Features

Dell's E228WFP is an older monitor that was well ahead of its time. This display is extremely well built with a matte finished black body and sports a very good fit and finish. The stand is excellent and looks super sleek and all mechanical parts seem extremely rugged. The ultra slim bezel adds to its appeal, while the menu system is also intuitive and the buttons very usable. HP's LE2201w also sports an industrial grade finish and although it's not as sleek as the E228WFP, most will appreciate the great build quality, although we doubt it's aesthetics as it has a rather squat, unappealing look.

ASUS' VK222Hs bezel is narrow enough for it to pass as sleek and the contoured design is neat. The menu system is well laid out, unfortunately it has horrible buttons like its larger sibling. ViewSonic's VX2233 sports a piano black finish that is the norm these days and this display has a narrow bezel surrounding a high-resolution (1920 x 1080 pixels) screen. The DVI port is extremely close to the barrel of the stand and inserting a DVI cable isn't easy as the width of the connector means it foils with the stand.